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YOUTH CAMP PIQUES INTEREST IN SCIENCE - SPACE STATION DESIGN EARNS AWARD

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A dozen pupils at Oak Hills Elementary School spent their spring break designing a titanium space station with a $7 billion price tag.

The exercise, part of a week of programs at the Space Camp at the U.S. Space and Rocket Center in Huntsville, Ala., earned the fourth- and fifth- graders an award for best presentation among campers who attended April 18 through Friday.

"We won a pin for best presentation," said fifth-grader Jesse Gabriel, 11. "We had to design it (the space station), come up with a budget, what to do in an emergency and how long it will be in use. We named it the U.S. Space Center. We planned on putting it into space in the year 2000 for 30 years."

Becky Koch, a fourth-grade teacher who helped chaperon the pupils, said the camp is designed to get children excited about space, science and math so they might pursue related careers. Over the course of a year, about 20,000 pupils from throughout the United States will visit the Space Camp, she said.

Area pupils, who each paid $495 each for registration and air fare, spent their busy days launching rockets into space, tumbling around in a simulator and building the space station as they earned their flight wings.

Fourth-grader Jennifer Friedricks, 10, earned the Outstanding Trainee Award through a vote of fellow campers. Brian McCallion of Medea Creek Middle School, whose brother Keith was among the Oak Hills pupils at the camp, was named Outstanding Cadet for his division.

"This was the best group with a good attitude," Koch said. "Everyone was complimenting them. The camp was outstanding."

The pupils started each day at 6:30 a.m. with one hour to prepare for their busy schedule. At 7:30 each morning, pupils did a half-hour of conditioning exercises such as push-ups and jumping jacks before eating breakfast and heading for class, which lasted until 9 each evening.

During the week, pupils participated in a simulated splashdown that included a swim to a rescue raft, learned the basics of geology and launched a model rocket, Koch said.

The group also was able to sit on gravity chairs and watch movies in an Imax theater, which features a giant screen.

"I had to put on a space suit to launch a rocket," said fourth-grader Allison Misle, 9. "I got to sit in a space simulator, push the buttons and watch the satellite go up. It was called extra-vehicular activity."

Fifth-grader Patrick Monroe, 11, like the simulator best. "It turned you every way that simulated a tumbling space craft," he said.

Enid Miller, a fifth-grade teacher who also helped chaperon, said the pupils were well-behaved and enjoyed themselves.

"The group we had was perfect," she said. "They were the best group to get the most out of the experience. They

were enthusiastic and worked hard. Their excitement was contagious to me."

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